

Ashford University Research Degrees Handbook

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Foreword

This handbook is produced by the Ashford University Research Office and is intended as a practical guide for students enrolled in research degree programmes, including Master of Research (MRes), Master of Philosophy (MPhil), and Doctor of Philosophy (PhD) programmes. It should be read alongside the Ashford University Graduate Studies Policy and Academic Regulations. Where this handbook provides operational guidance that is consistent with those documents, it takes precedence as a practical procedural reference. Where substantive policy matters are addressed differently, students should seek clarification from the Office of Graduate Studies.

This handbook is updated annually. Students should ensure they are consulting the version current for their academic year of enrolment.

Chapter 1: Research Degree Structures

1.1 Master of Research (MRes)

The MRes is a twelve-month full-time (or twenty-four month part-time) programme combining taught elements with a substantial research project. The research component typically constitutes 60% of the total credit hours. Students completing an MRes are expected to demonstrate the ability to conduct independent research and to present findings in a format that meets scholarly standards.

1.2 Master of Philosophy (MPhil)

The MPhil is a research-only degree, normally completed in two years full-time (or four years part-time). The programme centres on an original research thesis examined by internal and external examiners. MPhil students may, with the approval of the Graduate Studies Committee, upgrade their registration to PhD candidacy, provided they demonstrate that the scope and originality of the work meets doctoral standards.

1.3 Doctor of Philosophy (PhD)

The PhD programme requires the completion of a thesis that makes an original and substantial contribution to knowledge in the field. The standard duration is three years full-time (or six years part-time). Students are expected to reach the stage of thesis submission within the standard duration. The Graduate Studies Committee may approve extensions under the conditions set out in Chapter 8 of this handbook.

Chapter 2: Enrolment and Registration

2.1 Annual Re-Registration

Research degree students must re-register annually at the start of each academic year. Re-registration is not automatic; students must confirm their continued enrolment through the student portal and pay the applicable programme continuation fee listed in the Fee Schedule (FSP-2024-003).

Failure to re-register within four weeks of the start of the academic year will result in lapse of registration. A student whose registration lapses must apply for reinstatement through the Office of Graduate Studies. Reinstatement is not guaranteed and may require a new ethics clearance for ongoing research.

2.2 Part-Time Registration

Students registered as part-time research students have all the same rights and obligations as full-time students but with adjusted expected progression timelines. Part-time students should note that funding arrangements, including assistantships and scholarships, are typically structured for full-time registration.

2.3 Registration Status and Thesis Completion

A student who has submitted their thesis for examination but has not yet received the outcome remains registered as a student and retains access to University facilities. A student whose thesis has been examined with a result of pass (with or without corrections) will remain registered until any required corrections are certified complete.

Chapter 3: Supervision

3.1 Role of the Primary Supervisor

The primary supervisor is the principal academic contact for the research student. The supervisor's responsibilities include:

- Meeting with the student regularly (at least monthly during active research phases and at least twice per term during writing-up phases).
- Providing written feedback on chapter drafts within four weeks of submission.
- Certifying the student's Annual Progress Review.
- Advising on the suitability of the thesis for submission.

Students who experience difficulties with supervision should raise the matter with the Programme Director in the first instance, and with the Research Office if the matter is not resolved.

3.2 Absence of Supervisor

Where a supervisor is temporarily unavailable (e.g., due to sabbatical, illness, or other leave), the Programme Director will arrange for interim supervisory support. Where a supervisor's absence is expected to exceed three months, a formal interim supervisor shall be appointed by the Graduate Studies Committee.

Chapter 4: Annual Progress Review

4.1 Purpose

Research degree students must undergo an Annual Progress Review (APR) at the end of each academic year. The APR assesses whether the student is making adequate progress toward the completion of their research degree within the expected timeframe.

4.2 APR Components

A standard APR includes:

- A written progress report submitted by the student.
- A supervisor's assessment.
- An oral review with a panel of at least two academic staff (neither of whom is the student's supervisor).

4.3 APR Outcomes

The panel may determine:

- Satisfactory progress: Student continues at the current registration level.
 - Conditional progress: Student is set specific targets to be reviewed at a mid-year check-in.
 - Transfer to lower degree: Where doctoral progress is not demonstrated, the student may be transferred to MPhil registration.
 - Referral for withdrawal: Where progress is so seriously deficient that continuation cannot be justified.
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Chapter 5: Research Integrity and Ethics

5.1 Ethics Approval

All research involving human participants, animal subjects, or sensitive personal data must obtain ethics approval from the University Research Ethics Board before any research activity begins. The requirement for ethics approval is absolute; no exceptions are granted on the grounds of time pressure or supervisory advice.

Research carried out without the required ethics approval is not eligible for inclusion in a thesis or for publication under the University's name.

5.2 Research Data Management

Research students are required to comply with the Ashford University Research Data Management Policy. In summary:

- A Data Management Plan must be submitted within three months of commencing research.
- All primary research data must be stored in a University-approved repository.
- Data underlying a thesis must be retained for a minimum of ten years.

5.3 Authorship and Publication

Where research students publish or co-author work arising from their research, they must comply with the University's Authorship Policy. Guest or gift authorship is prohibited. Supervisors who contribute substantively to a publication may be listed as co-authors with the student's agreement.

Chapter 6: Progression Milestones

6.1 MPhil/PhD Transfer

MPhil students seeking to transfer to PhD registration must demonstrate that their research has doctoral scope and originality. The transfer assessment includes:

- Submission of a transfer report (typically 5,000–10,000 words) describing the research question, methodology, preliminary findings, and proposed thesis structure.
- An oral assessment with a panel of two academic staff members.

Transfer decisions must be approved by the Graduate Studies Committee. Students must apply for transfer no later than eighteen months into full-time registration (thirty-six months for part-time).

6.2 Thesis Completion Stage

A student who has completed data collection and analysis and has begun full-time thesis writing may apply to be designated at the Completion Stage. At the Completion Stage:

- The student's primary obligation is thesis writing.
- The student may reduce their supervisory contact to a minimum of once per month.
- The student's registration fee may be reduced (see FSP-2024-003 for completion stage fees).

Chapter 7: Examination

7.1 Notice of Submission

A student must submit a Notice of Intention to Submit to the Office of Graduate Studies at least two months before they intend to submit the thesis. This notice triggers the appointment of the examination panel by the Graduate Studies Committee.

7.2 Examination Panel Composition

The examination panel for a PhD must include:

- At least one external examiner (from outside the University).
- At least one internal examiner (from within the University, but not the student's supervisor or co-supervisor).

The Graduate Studies Committee appoints all examiners. Students may suggest potential external examiners but must declare any relationship that might constitute a conflict of interest.

7.3 The Oral Defence

The oral defence is conducted in person at the University's main campus unless special circumstances are approved in advance by the Dean of Graduate Studies. Remote oral defences may be approved where the student is based overseas or faces significant documented travel constraints.

The oral defence is conducted by the examination panel and is an opportunity for the student to defend the contribution and findings of their thesis. The oral typically lasts two to four hours. Observers (including supervisors) may attend with the panel's consent but may not participate.

Chapter 8: Extensions to Thesis Submission Deadlines

8.1 General Policy

Research degree students are expected to complete and submit their thesis within the standard duration of their programme. The University recognises that research is inherently unpredictable, and provision is made for extensions in genuine cases of documented difficulty.

8.2 Short Extensions

Where a student requires a short extension of fewer than four weeks to complete final revisions to their thesis, the primary supervisor may grant this directly without formal committee approval. The supervisor must notify the Office of Graduate Studies in writing within five business days of granting such an extension.

8.3 Formal Extensions

[C-003 — Source B]

Where a research degree student requires a more substantial extension due to circumstances beyond their control — such as prolonged illness, equipment failure affecting experimental work, or significant unexpected obstacles to fieldwork — the Dean of Graduate Studies may grant an extension of up to six months upon recommendation of the Graduate Studies Committee.

The application for a formal extension must be submitted to the Research Office, accompanied by a supervisor's supporting statement and appropriate documentary evidence. The Dean of Graduate Studies has sole authority to approve or deny formal extension requests exceeding four weeks, and may grant extensions up to a maximum of six months.

An extension of more than six months may be granted only in truly exceptional circumstances, requires the approval of the Research and Innovation Committee, and will normally result in a temporary change in the student's registration status.

8.4 Extensions and Financial Obligations

A student who is granted a formal extension remains registered and is subject to applicable continuation fees for the duration of the extension period. Fee obligations during an approved extension are set out in FSP-2024-003. The Research Office will notify the Bursar's Office of the revised expected completion date.

Chapter 9: Completion, Award, and Alumni Status

9.1 Certification of Thesis Corrections

Where the examination panel requires minor or major corrections, the primary supervisor is responsible for certifying that corrections have been completed to the required standard. The supervisor must submit certification to the Office of Graduate Studies within the deadline set by the examination panel. Failure to certify corrections within the required period will cause the award to be withheld until certification is received.

9.2 Thesis Deposit and Open Access

All approved theses must be deposited in the Ashford University Thesis Repository. Open access to the thesis is the default. An embargo may be requested at the time of submission for a period of up to two years where there is a documented and compelling reason (e.g., pending patent application, commercial sensitivity of findings, or imminent publication in a peer-reviewed journal). Embargoes beyond two years require Research and Innovation Committee approval and are granted only in exceptional circumstances.

9.3 Conferral of Award

The degree is formally conferred at the next Commencement ceremony following the Registrar's confirmation of completion. A student who has completed all requirements may request interim certification of completion for professional purposes before the formal conferral date.

9.4 Alumni Status

Upon conferral of the degree, graduates of research programmes become alumni of Ashford University and are entitled to access alumni services, the library's digital collections (read-only), and the University's career development resources for a period of three years post-graduation.

